

BUSH FOODS · DOCUMENTATION

A season of bush foods.

What grows here, how we've always used it, and what the science is now confirming.

Harvesting on Turraburra isn't run out of a greenhouse. What grows here mostly grows the way it always has, in situ, across the property — permaculture in the oldest sense of the word, not a garden bed.

Native lemongrass — *Cymbopogon ambiguus*

An aromatic native grass we've long used to treat chest infections, headaches, muscle cramps and skin sores — most often as a tea, or inhaled as steam. Research out of Griffith University later found its compounds comparable to aspirin for treating headaches and inflammation.

We harvest it directly off the property. One batch went into a small-run gin, a distillery collaboration born from a shared Longreach connection to Qantas — more curiosity than commercial plan.

Eight more plants we've long used are now part of a formal research panel, run with the Tropical Indigenous Ethnobotany Centre, the Australian Tropical Herbarium and James Cook University.

Gumbi gumbi — *Pittosporum angustifolium*

Also called native apricot, though we don't eat the fruit. We traditionally dry the leaves and steep them as a tea, used for coughs, colds and skin complaints.

The research panel found real antioxidant and anti-inflammatory activity in the leaf extract — and also found it was the most cytotoxic of the eight to human cells in lab testing. Worth saying plainly, not glossed over.

Quinine berry — *Petalostigma pubescens*

Small orange fruit we chew for toothache, or infuse as an antiseptic wash for sore eyes. Despite the name, it doesn't actually contain quinine.

What it does contain, in unusually high concentration, is shikimic acid — the compound synthesised into the antiviral drug Tamiflu.

Hop bush — *Dodonaea tenuifolia*

One of the bush medicines we use most, typically for pain and inflammation. Extract testing found the same alkaloid and flavonoid profile that shows up across most of the eight species in the panel.

Plum bush — *Santalum lanceolatum*

A relative of the desert quandong, with small edible fruit and a use we've long had for the bark and leaf.

Native cotton — *Gossypium australe*

Better known to us as fibre than food, and less studied than the others on this list — one of the reasons we included it in the research panel rather than assuming what it does.

Velleia macrocalyx

The least documented of the six named species — small, yellow-flowered, part of the same open woodland Country as the rest. Written documentation of it is new. The use isn't.

And two more

Two of the eight species we gave for testing aren't named here at all — recorded in the research only by voucher code. That knowledge stays with us.

Across the panel, screening confirmed alkaloids, phenolics, flavonoids and terpenoids. Seven of the eight extracts measurably suppressed inflammatory markers in lab testing, with antioxidant activity ranging from moderate to strong.

The study's own conclusion: scientific validation for knowledge we never needed validated.

Native lemongrass traditional use and Griffith University research via published ethnobotanical sources. Iningai medicinal plant panel: Phytochemical Composition and Antioxidant and Anti-Inflammatory Activities of Iningai Aboriginal Medicinal Plants From Central Queensland, Australia — Tropical Indigenous Ethnobotany Centre, Australian Tropical Herbarium and James Cook University, 2026.